A REFUGE IN THE DAY OF DISTRESS · SESSION 1

A Refuge in the Day of Distress

Nahum 1:1–14

TO GET STARTED

Think of a time you were caught out by a sudden storm, a power cut or a breakdown on the road. Where did you go to find shelter – and what made it feel safe?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Nahum prophesied in the seventh century BC (roughly between 663 and 612 BC), when Assyria was the undisputed world power and Nineveh its seemingly invincible capital. About a century earlier Jonah had preached there, the city repented, and God spared it; but Nineveh slid back into cruelty, idolatry and bloodshed, carried northern Israel into exile in 722 BC and kept squeezing little Judah. Nahum's name means “comfort”: tonight we hear the LORD's majesty in a poem (1:2–8) and then his words turning in turn to Nineveh and to Judah (1:9–14).

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:1–2

[1] An oracle concerning Nineveh. The book of the vision of Nahum the Elkoshite.

[2] A jealous God, one who takes vengeance, is the LORD;
the LORD takes vengeance and is full of wrath.
The LORD takes vengeance on his adversaries
and holds it against his enemies.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:3–3

3 The LORD is slow to anger and great in power,
and the LORD will surely not acquit the guilty.
In whirlwind and in storm is his way,
and clouds are the dust of his feet.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:4–4

4 He rebukes the sea and makes it dry,
and all the rivers he dries up.
Bashan and Carmel wither,
and the blossom of Lebanon withers.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:5–5

5 The mountains shake because of him,
and the hills melt away;
the earth rises up before his face,
the world and all who live in it.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:6–6

6 Before his fury who can stand?
Who can rise up against his burning anger?
His wrath pours out like fire,
and the rocks are torn down by him.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:7–8

7 The LORD is good,
a refuge in the day of distress;
he knows those who shelter in him.
8 But with a flood that passes over
he will make a full end of her place,
and his enemies he will pursue into darkness.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:9–10

9 What are you devising against the LORD?
He is making a full end;
distress will not rise up a second time.
10 For even if they are like tangled thorns
and drunk as with their drink,
they are devoured like dry stubble, completely.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:11–11

11 From you has come out
one who devises evil against the LORD,
one who counsels what is worthless.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:12–12

12 Thus says the LORD:
Though they are at full strength and ever so many,
even so they will be shorn and pass away.
I have afflicted you;
I will afflict you no more.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:13–13

13 And now I will break his yoke from off you
and tear your bonds apart.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 1:14–14

14 But concerning you the LORD has commanded:
Nothing more will be sown that bears your name.
From the house of your gods I will cut off
carved image and cast image;
I will make your grave,
for you weigh nothing.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

אֵל קַנּוֹא

El qanno' · "A jealous God"

The book opens with "A jealous God, one who takes vengeance, is the LORD" (1:2). This is not petty human envy but the fiery, protective love of the covenant God who will not stand by while his people are destroyed. Three times the verse says the LORD "takes vengeance" (noqem): not a loss of control, but the Judge of all the earth putting things right.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

מָעוֹז

ma'oz · "refuge"

The anchor verse of the book, which gives this series its title: "The LORD is good, a refuge in the day of distress; he knows those who shelter in him." (1:7). A ma'oz is a mountain stronghold, an impregnable fortress, and "knows" speaks of intimate, personal care. The same word "distress" (tsarah) returns in 1:9: the distress in which God is a refuge is the distress he brings to an end.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

קַלּוֹתָ

qallota · “you weigh nothing”

God's sentence on the Assyrian king ends: “I will make your grave, for you weigh nothing.” (1:14). Qalal means to be light, weightless, of no account – much like Belshazzar in Daniel 5:27, weighed on the scales and found too light. The world thought Assyria a heavyweight; on God's scales its pride weighs nothing.

THE BIG IDEA

The LORD who is slow to anger is also the Judge who will not let evil go on for ever – and that same God is good, a refuge for everyone who shelters in him and the One who breaks the yoke of the oppressed.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Nahum begins not with Nineveh but with a portrait of God: jealous, taking vengeance, “slow to anger and great in power”. Which of these words do you find hardest, and which do you find most comforting? Why?

Nahum 1:2–3

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“The LORD is slow to anger” – the very words Jonah used of God (Jonah 4:2) when Nineveh was spared. God had given the city about a century. How do we tell God's patience apart from his absence when the wicked seem to prosper?

Nahum 1:3

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Assyria boasted of horses, chariots and walls, but for the LORD “clouds are the dust of his feet”, and Bashan, Carmel and Lebanon wither at his word. How does this picture of God's power change the size of the problems that loom largest for you?

Nahum 1:3–6

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Verse 7 does not promise that there will be no “day of distress” – it assumes such days will come. Where do you usually run first when the storm breaks: control, distraction, other people, or the Lord? What would sheltering in him look like this week?

Nahum 1:7–8

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“What are you devising against the LORD?” The Assyrians thought they were simply fighting a small state called Judah. What does it mean that to touch God's people is to plot against God himself?

Nahum 1:9–11

DISCUSSION · 6/7

To Judah God says: “I have afflicted you; I will afflict you no more.” Assyria had been the rod of his discipline (Isaiah 10:5), but the season was over. What “yoke” or “bonds” do you long for God to break – and how does it help to know that every hard season has an expiry date?

Nahum 1:12–13

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The problems or people that intimidate us can look like “tangled thorns”, yet on God's scales they weigh nothing. What in your life are you giving more weight than God's promises? Share only what you are comfortable sharing.

Nahum 1:10–14

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write out 1:7 and put it where you will see it each day. When a moment of distress comes this week, read it aloud and name the specific thing you are bringing to your refuge.
- Is there someone who has wronged you and whom you would like to pay back? Following Romans 12:19, give the case to God in prayer each day this week and ask him to free you from bitterness.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by thanking God together for who he is in 1:2–7: holy, patient, mighty and good. Then pray in pairs or threes for the “days of distress” each person is facing, and for the yokes people long to see broken, asking the LORD to be their refuge. Close by praying for those in the world today who live under oppression.

A REFUGE IN THE DAY OF DISTRESS · SESSION 2

The Lions' Den Plundered

Nahum 2:1–14

TO GET STARTED

What is the best piece of news you have ever received – and how did you hear it (a call, a letter, someone at the door)?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Last week ended with God breaking the yoke from Judah's neck and pronouncing the grave of the Assyrian king (1:12–14). Chapter 2 opens with a messenger running over the mountains with news of peace (2:1; English 1:15), and then shows how Nineveh will fall: the attackers storm in, the river gates are opened, and the city's wealth drains away (2:2–11; English 2:1–10). Nahum probably wrote this decades before 612 BC, when Babylonians and Medes destroyed the city. The chapter ends with a taunt over the lions' den – the lion was the Assyrian kings' own royal symbol (2:12–14; English 2:11–13). (Our verse numbers are Hebrew: in English Bibles subtract one throughout this chapter, and 2:1 is 1:15.)

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:1–1

[1] Look, on the mountains
the feet of one who brings good news,
who announces peace!
Keep your festivals, Judah,
pay your vows!
For never again will the worthless one
pass through you;
he is cut off completely. (*English Bibles*: 1:15)

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:2–2

[2] One who scatters has come up against you.
Guard the rampart!
Watch the road!
Brace your loins!
Gather all your strength! (*English Bibles: 2:1; from here on subtract one from the verse number*)

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:3–3

3 For the LORD restores the majesty of Jacob
like the majesty of Israel;
for plunderers have plundered them
and ruined their vine branches.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:4–4

4 The shield of his warriors is reddened,
the men of valour are clothed in scarlet;
the chariots flash with the fire of steel
on the day he makes ready,
and the cypress spears are brandished.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:5–5

5 In the streets the chariots rage,
they rush to and fro in the squares;
their appearance is like torches,
like lightning they dart about.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:6–7

6 He remembers his nobles;
they stumble as they go;
they hurry to her wall,
and the protective cover is set up.
7 The gates of the rivers are opened,
and the palace melts away.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:8–8

8 And it is fixed: she is stripped, she is carried away,
and her slave women moan
like the sound of doves,
beating on their breasts.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:9–9

9 Nineveh is like a pool of water
all her days;
but now they are fleeing.
"Stop! Stop!" –
but no one turns back.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:10–10

10 Plunder silver! Plunder gold!
There is no end to the treasure,
wealth heavy with every precious thing.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:11–11

11 Empty! Emptied! Laid waste!
The heart melts, the knees knock,
trembling is in all loins,
and all their faces grow pale.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:12–12

12 Where now is the lions' den,
the pasture of the young lions,
where the lion walked, the lioness,
there the lion's cub,
and no one made them afraid?

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:13–13

13 The lion tore enough for his cubs
and strangled prey for his lionesses;
he filled his holes with prey
and his dens with torn flesh.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 2:14–14

14 Look, I am against you
– declares the LORD of hosts –
I will burn her chariots in smoke,
and the sword will devour your young lions;
I will cut off your prey from the earth,
and the voice of your messengers
will be heard no more.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

מְבַשֵּׂר

mevasser · "one who brings good news"

"Look, on the mountains the feet of one who brings good news, who announces peace!" (2:1; English 1:15). The Greek Old Testament renders this verb with euangelizomai, the root of the New Testament word "gospel". The verse is almost the same as Isaiah 52:7, which Paul quotes in Romans 10:15 for the preaching of Christ, and the news is shalom: peace, wholeness, safety.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

נָמוֹג

namog · “melts away”

“The gates of the rivers are opened, and the palace melts away.” (2:7; English 2:6). It is the same verb as in 1:5, where the hills melt away before the LORD. The water that was Nineveh's greatest protection becomes, in God's hand, the instrument of its downfall.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

בּוּקָה וּמְבוּקָה וּמְבֻלָּקָה

buqah umevuqah umevullaqah · “Empty! Emptied! Laid waste!”

One of the most striking sound plays in the Bible (2:11; English 2:10): the syllables build from two to three to four, like water glugging out of a bottle or walls rumbling down. Everything Nineveh had hoarded from the nations ends in emptiness.

THE BIG IDEA

The good news of peace for God's people means the end of the oppressor: the walls, rivers and treasures that Nineveh trusted melt away, the lions' den falls silent, and the LORD of hosts himself says to the proud, “Look, I am against you”.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

The watchmen on Jerusalem's walls waited to see how a runner came over the hills. For Judah the news meant: “Keep your festivals, Judah, pay your vows!” What good news do you need to hear today – and how does the news of Christ's victory call you back to worship before every problem is solved?

Nahum 2:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

“Guard the rampart! Watch the road!” – the prophet mockingly dares Nineveh to put up its best defence. Where do you see people (or yourself) preparing feverishly against what God has decided?

Nahum 2:2

DISCUSSION · 3/7

In the middle of the battle comes the reason: “For the LORD restores the majesty of Jacob like the majesty of Israel; for plunderers have plundered them and ruined their vine branches.” Where do you feel that your “vine branches” have been plundered? What hope does it give that God's judgement on evil serves his plan to restore?

Nahum 2:3

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Nineveh trusted its huge walls and river system, yet “the palace melts away”. What are the “walls of Nineveh” we build for ourselves – money, career, intellect, reputation? What happens to them when the floodwaters of life rise?

Nahum 2:6–7

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“Nineveh is like a pool of water” – wealth and people dammed up for decades, now draining away: “Empty! Emptied! Laid waste!” Compare Jesus' parable of the rich fool (Luke 12:15–21). Where are we tempted to build our own “lions' den” of possessions and status?

Nahum 2:9–11

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“Where now is the lions' den … and no one made them afraid?” Assyria saw itself as the predator no one could stop. Then God speaks in the first person: “Look, I am against you – declares the LORD of hosts –”. How do James 4:6 and Romans 8:31 (“If God is for us, who is against us?”) help us hear this verse rightly?

Nahum 2:12–14

DISCUSSION · 7/7

The chapter ends: “and the voice of your messengers will be heard no more” – the envoys who mocked the living God outside Jerusalem (2 Kings 18). Which intimidating voices (fear, accusation, old shame) are loudest in your ears? How can you trust the LORD of hosts to silence them?

Nahum 2:14

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one “wall of Nineveh” you lean on instead of God. Each day this week, tell him honestly what you would be afraid of if it fell away, and ask him to be your refuge instead (1:7).
- Be a “messenger of good news” this week: bring a word of peace, hope or encouragement to one person who is under pressure – in person, by message or by a call.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by thanking God for the good news of peace in Christ (2:1). Then let each person name, aloud or silently, one intimidating voice they want God to silence, and pray for one another. End by praying that God would restore what has been plundered in the lives of people in the group.

A REFUGE IN THE DAY OF DISTRESS · SESSION 3

Woe to the City of Bloodshed

Nahum 3:1–19

TO GET STARTED

Think of a product, a place or a promise that looked wonderful in the advert but turned out very different in real life. What gave it away?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 2 showed how Nineveh would fall; chapter 3 shows why. It opens with the cry “Woe!” – both an indictment and a funeral lament – and exposes a city built on blood, deceit and occult seduction (3:1–7). Then Nahum points to No-Amon (Thebes in Egypt), which Assyria itself conquered in 663 BC: if that city with water all around her fell, so will Nineveh (3:8–13). The book ends with mocking calls to strengthen the walls, the image of locusts that fly away, and a lament over the king of Assyria – closing, like Jonah, with a question (3:14–19).

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:1–1

[1] Woe to the city of bloodshed!
All of it is lies,
full of plunder;
the prey never departs.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:2–2

2 The crack of the whip
and the rumble of the wheel,
the galloping horse
and the jolting chariot!

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:3–3

3 Horsemen charging,
the flame of the sword and the lightning of the spear,
a multitude of slain,
a heavy mass of corpses,
no end to the bodies –
they stumble over their bodies.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:4–4

4 All this because of the many harlotries of the prostitute,
lovely and charming,
mistress of sorceries,
who sells nations through her harlotries
and clans through her sorceries.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:5–5

5 Look, I am against you
– declares the LORD of hosts –
I will lift your skirts over your face
and let the nations see your nakedness
and the kingdoms your shame.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:6–6

6 I will throw filth on you,
treat you with contempt,
and make you a spectacle.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:7–7

7 And everyone who sees you
will flee from you and say:
"Nineveh is devastated!
Who will grieve for her?"
Where shall I seek comforters for you?

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:8–8

[8] Are you better than No-Amon,
who sat by the channels of the Nile,
with water all around her,
whose rampart was the sea,
her wall from the sea?

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:9–9

9 Cush was her strength, and Egypt,
and there was no end;
Put and the Libyans
were among your helpers.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:10–10

10 Yet she too went into exile,
she went into captivity;
her little children too were dashed to pieces
at the head of every street;
for her honoured men they cast lots,
and all her great men were bound in chains.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:11–11

11 You too will be drunk,
you will be hidden away;
you too will seek a refuge from the enemy.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:12–12

12 All your fortresses are fig trees
with first-ripe figs:
if they are shaken,
they fall into the mouth of the eater.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:13–13

13 Look, your people are women in your midst;
to your enemies the gates of your land
are thrown wide open;
fire has devoured your bars.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:14–14

14 Draw water for the siege!
Strengthen your fortresses!
Go into the clay
and tread the mortar!
Take hold of the brick mould!

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:15–15

15 There the fire will devour you,
the sword will cut you off;
it will devour you like the hopper.
Make yourself many like the hopper,
make yourself many like the locust!

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:16–16

16 You have made your merchants more numerous
than the stars of the sky;
the hopper sheds its skin and flies away.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:17–17

17 Your guards are like the locust,
your officials like a swarm of locusts
that settle in the walls
on a cold day;
when the sun rises, it flees,
and its place is not known – where are they?

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:18–18

18 Your shepherds slumber, king of Assyria;
your nobles lie down to rest;
your people are scattered on the mountains,
and there is no one to assemble them.

READ TOGETHER · NAHUM 3:19–19

19 There is no easing for your fracture;
your wound is grievous.
All who hear the news of you
clap their hands over you;
for over whom has your evil not passed
continually?

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

עִיר דָּמִים

'ir damim · “city of bloodshed”

Literally “city of bloods” – plural, bloody deeds. Verse 1 sums up Nineveh in four charges: “Woe to the city of bloodshed! All of it is lies, full of plunder; the prey never departs.” Its splendour had been bought with human blood, its treaties were deceit (kachash), and like a predator it was never satisfied.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

מְנַחֲמִים

menachamim · "comforters"

"Where shall I seek comforters for you?" (3:7). The word comes from the same root as the prophet's name, Nahum (Nachum), "comfort". Nahum brings rich comfort to oppressed Judah, but for cruel, unrepentant Nineveh no comforter can be found.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

מָעוֹז

ma'oz · "refuge"

"You too will seek a refuge from the enemy." (3:11). It is the same word as in 1:7: "The LORD is good, a refuge in the day of distress". Nineveh looks for a refuge and finds none; the LORD alone is the refuge that does not fall.

THE BIG IDEA

God sees through the charm of violence, lies and seduction and brings it to an end: Nineveh finds no comforter and no refuge, its allies fly away like locusts – but the LORD remains good, the refuge that never falls, and the Good Shepherd who never slumbers.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Read the four charges of verse 1. Which of them – violence, lies, plunder, never being satisfied – do you see most clearly in the systems of our world today? Where are we ourselves tempted to bend the truth or get ahead at others' expense?

Nahum 3:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Nineveh is pictured as a prostitute, “lovely and charming, mistress of sorceries”, “who sells nations through her harlotries”. Day 5 says sin never knocks at the door in its true form. Which temptations look “lovely and charming” to you, and where do they lead in the end?

Nahum 3:4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“Who will grieve for her?” Nineveh had used everyone and had no one to comfort her when she fell. How do you treat people when you are in a position of strength? Who could you comfort this week, as the Holy Spirit, the true Comforter, comforts you?

Nahum 3:7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“Are you better than No-Amon”? Nineveh's own history proved that rivers and armies do not make a city untouchable. What “past examples” do we ignore because we think it could never happen to us?

Nahum 3:8–11

DISCUSSION · 5/7

“Go into the clay and tread the mortar! Take hold of the brick mould!” Nineveh feverishly tried to repair its walls in its own strength instead of humbling itself before God. Where are you “baking bricks” to control a situation you really need to surrender to the Lord?

Nahum 3:14

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Nineveh's merchants, guards and officials were like locusts – many in good times, gone “when the sun rises”. Have you experienced people or supports disappearing in a crisis? How does that help you rest in the Good Shepherd, who does not slumber or fly away (Psalm 121:4; John 10:11–12)?

Nahum 3:16–18

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Jonah ends with God's question of grace over a repentant Nineveh (Jonah 4:11); Nahum ends with “for over whom has your evil not passed continually?” What do the two endings together teach us about God? And looking back over the whole series: which truth about God has comforted you most?

Nahum 3:19

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Ask the Holy Spirit each day this week to show you one place where you keep up a mask – of success, of having it all together, of religion – and bring it to God in honesty.
- Choose one person who has been hurt by the harshness of the world and be a voice of God's comfort to them this week: a visit, a meal, a message or a prayer together.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a few moments of silent confession, asking God to cleanse anything built on dishonesty or on wronging others. Then thank him together for the Good Shepherd, who took our “fracture” on himself so that through his wounds we are healed (Isaiah 53:5). Close by reading 1:7 aloud together as the summary of the whole series.